



## Beyond The Cliches

**W**e did not commission a Gen Z survey to chase a buzzword. We did it because India's youngest adults are too large, and too consequential a cohort, to be understood through cliches. This special edition, to mark the 34th Anniversary of *Business Today*, is centred around consumption patterns of an estimated 420 million Indians in the 15–29 age group, accounting for nearly 29% of our population. If India is home to almost one in five of the world's young people, their choices matter.

Yet the public narrative about Gen Z is perhaps misinformed by the lack of empirical studies. Gen Z is painted as carefree, restless, and always online. They are assumed to be price-led and easily swayed by influencers and discounts. We wanted to test these assumptions.

So, we partnered with People Research on India's Consumer Economy (PRICE) to build a primary, multi-city survey that could decode Gen Z consumers. Fieldwork was carried out in early December 2025, covering 4,311 respondents across four metros and eight Tier II cities. The questions examined consumption behaviours across 34 topics.

What did we discover? The first and most important insight is that Gen Z is not stepping away from consumption. Demand is very much alive—84% of respondents expect their overall spending to rise in the next 12 months. More than half aspire to both home and car ownership. Besides, 57% save more than 20% of their income. This is not the popular image of a spend-now generation.

The second major insight is that product quality is the top purchase driver at 43%, well ahead of price at 20%. Brand reputation follows at 26%, while influencer recommendations are a distant 6%. It is clear that Gen Z responds to performance and proof. That is also why loyalty is conditional. Nearly eight in 10 are willing to switch brands if a better option emerges.

Where is Gen Z spending today? In categories without a long lock-in. Fashion, gadgets and electronics, food, and experiences dominate current outlay. While premium is part of the mix, it is more of sampling. Over seven in 10 acquire premium or luxury brands occasionally or regularly, while “only premium” behaviour remains limited to the top income segment.

The digital aspect too needs a better filter. Instagram leads as the most influential platform at 44%, followed by YouTube at 25%. But influence is different from purchase. Gen Z buys only rarely or sometimes after seeing products on social media. Shopping journeys are fragmented—quick commerce is the default convenience channel for daily needs, while physical retail holds its ground where touch and feel matter, and e-commerce serves planned buys and comparisons.

Credit behaviour is another break from the template. Two-thirds say they rarely or never borrow for discretionary spending. When borrowing does happen, informal sources dominate. This is a cohort that prefers control over leverage, especially for lifestyle spends.

For India Inc, the broader learning for winning over Gen Z is simple: do not just sell them a moment, earn their trust. **BT**

*Siddharth*

siddharth.zarabi@businesstoday.in  
@sazarabi

# Business Today

<http://www.businesstoday.in>

**Chairman & Editor-in-Chief:** Aroon Purie  
**Vice Chairperson & Executive Editor-in-Chief:** Kalli Purie  
**Group Chief Executive Officer:** Dinesh Bhatia  
**Chief Operating Officer:** Alok Nair  
**Group Editor:** Siddharth Zarabi  
**Chief AI Officer, Group Creative Editor:** Nilanjan Das  
**Group Photo Editor:** Bandeeep Singh  
**Executive Editor:** Krishna Gopalan

**Editor (Special Projects):** Tina Edwin  
**Economy Editor:** Surabhi  
**Senior Editor:** Neeetu Chandra Sharma

**Associate Editors:** Chetan Bhutani, Karan Dhar  
**Senior Assistant Editors:** Palak Agarwal, Richa Sharma  
**Special Correspondent:** Karishma Asoodani  
**Principal Correspondents:** Aastha Chopra, Aishwarya Patil

**RESEARCH**  
**Chief of Research Bureau:** Rahul Oberoi  
**Deputy Research Analyst:** Prince Tyagi

**COPY DESK**  
**Senior Editor:** Mahesh Jagota  
**Associate Editor:** Vikram Gopal  
**Assistant Editors:** Bitasta Basu, Kamalika Ghosh

**PHOTOGRAPHY**  
**Senior Photographer:** Hardik Chhabra  
**Photo Coordinator:** Vidushi Mehrotra

**ART**  
**Art Director:** Rahul Sharma  
**Associate Art Directors:** Rajesh Kumar Angira, Raj Verma  
**Senior Designer:** Uma Shankar

**EVENTS**  
**Senior Manager:** Sourabh Dutta  
**PRODUCTION**  
**Chief of Production:** Harish Aggarwal  
**Production Manager:** Narendra Singh  
**Production Coordinator:** Ayeekpam David Meitei

**LIBRARY**  
**Assistant Librarian:** Satbir Singh  
**Executive Secretary:** Jyoti Kochhar

**BUSINESS TEAM**  
**Publisher:** Siddhartha Chatterjee  
**General Manager & North Head:** Ateet Dhandha  
**Assistant General Manager (Mumbai):** Rohit Subramanian  
**Assistant General Manager (Chennai):** P. Varunam  
**Assistant General Manager (Govt Sales):** Manoj Gotherwal

**AD OPS**  
**Deputy General Manager:** Avinash Karkera  
**Marketing:** Vivek Malhotra, Group Chief Marketing Officer  
**Newsstand Sales:** Deepak Bhatt,  
Assistant Vice President – Sales and Distribution;  
Rajeev Gandhi, General Manager (North);  
Yogesh Godhanlal Gautam, Regional Sales Manager (West);  
Manawer Hossain, Regional Sales Manager (East)

**Vol. 35, No. 3, for the fortnight January 19, 2026 to February 1, 2026. Released on January 19, 2026.**  
● Editorial Office: India Today Mediaplex, FC 8, Sector 16/A, Film City, Noida-201301; Tel: 0120-4807100; Fax: 0120-4807150 ● Advertising Office (Gurgaon): A1-A2, Enkay Centre, Ground Floor, V.N. Commercial Complex, Udyog Vihar, Phase 5, Gurgaon-122001; Tel: 0124-4948400; Fax: 0124-4030919; Mumbai: 1201, 12th Floor, Tower 2 A, One World Center (Jupiter Mills), S.B. Marg, Lower Parel (West), Mumbai-400013; Tel: 022-69193355; Fax: 022-66063226; Chennai: 5th Floor, Main Building No. 443, Guna Complex, Anna Salai, Teynampet, Chennai-600018; Tel: 044-28478525; Fax: 044-24361942; Bangalore: 202-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Tel: 080-22212448, 080-30374106; Fax: 080-22218335; Kolkata: 52, J.L. Road, 4th floor, Kolkata-700071; Tel: 033-22825398, 033-22827726, 033-22821922; Fax: 033-22827254; Hyderabad: 6-3-885/7/B, Raj Bhawan Road, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Tel: 040-23401657, 040-23400479; Ahmedabad: 2nd Floor, 2C, Surya Rath Building, Behind White House, Panchwati, Off: C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Tel: 079-6560393, 079-6560929; Fax: 079-6565293; Kochi: Karakatt Road, Kochi-682016; Tel: 0484-2377057, 0484-2377058; Fax: 0484-370962  
● Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, C-9, Sector-10, Noida (UP) - 201301.  
Email: [wecare@intoday.com](mailto:wecare@intoday.com) | Phone / Whatsapp: +91 8597 778 778 (Monday to Friday, 10 am-6 pm)  
● Sales: General Manager Sales, Living Media India Ltd, C-9, Sector 10, Noida (U.P.) - 201301; Tel: 0120-4919500; Fax: 0120-4919664 © 1998 Living Media India Ltd.  
All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited.  
● Printed & published by Manoj Sharma on behalf of Living Media India Limited. Printed at Thomson Press India Private Limited, 18-35, Milestone, Delhi-Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana). Published at F-26, First Floor, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001. Editor: Siddharth Zarabi  
● *Business Today* does not take responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material. All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent courts and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only.



For reprint rights and syndication enquiries, contact [syndications@intoday.com](mailto:syndications@intoday.com) or call +91-120-4078000

[www.syndicationtoday.in](http://www.syndicationtoday.in)